

needed it. Competitors who had spent a decade competing on specs suddenly had to compete on how a laptop felt in the hand, a metric none of them had tooled up for. Ive didn't just change what Apple made. He changed what the rest of the industry had to be capable of making.

The category resets

If the iMac and the unibody were rehearsals, the iPhone and iPad were the performance. The iPhone in 2007 didn't win by adding features, it won by removing almost all of them. One button. No stylus. No keyboard. At a time when Nokia and BlackBerry were competing on how many buttons and how much plastic they could cram onto a chassis, Ive's team shipped a slab of glass and dared the market to catch up. It did, but only by copying the grammar, not the philosophy. Samsung's earliest smartphone responses borrowed the rectangle and the glass front long before they borrowed any real design conviction of their own, and BlackBerry, the company with the most to lose, spent years insisting a physical keyboard was non-negotiable before quietly admitting it wasn't. Within three years, nearly every serious smartphone on the market was a glass rectangle with a single home button, regardless of whether the company making it believed in restraint or just recognised that customers now expected it. The iPad in 2010 did the same thing to a category that didn't exist yet, and got the same result: a shape that became mandatory before anyone had time to argue whether it was the right one.

LoveFrom and OpenAI

Ive left Apple in 2019 to make LoveFrom, a deliberately small, deliberately private studio that took on work Apple never would have: an icon overhaul for Airbnb, design language for Ferrari's first electric vehicle, even design consultation for the Vatican, projects

picked for craft rather than category or scale. It mattered less for what LoveFrom produced than for what it proved. Ive's instincts didn't belong to Apple's machine, the marketing budget, the retail stores, the twenty-year head start on consumer trust. They travelled with him, into rooms with no product roadmap and no shareholder call enforcing the discipline for him.

That's what makes the current chapter different from anything else in Ive's record. In May 2025, OpenAI acquired his hardware startup io in an all-stock deal worth roughly \$6.4 to \$6.5 billion, bringing Ive's team of around fifty-five people, including



former Apple hardware leads Evans Hankey and Tang Tan, in-house. Ive himself took on design responsibility not just for a single device but across OpenAI as a whole, while keeping LoveFrom running separately as his own studio. Sam Altman has talked about a "family of devices" meant to move the world past the smartphone entirely, screenless, voice-first, ambient, built to reduce screen dependency rather than deepen it. The specifics since then have been messier than the announcement suggested. The device, once floated for a second-half 2026 unveiling, is now not slated to ship before February 2027 according

to court filings. The name io itself got dropped entirely after a trademark dispute with a hearing-aid startup called iYo, forcing OpenAI to relaunch its hardware line without the one word that tied it to Ive's company.

None of that is a verdict on Ive, and it shouldn't be read as one. It's a structural shift worth naming, because it's the first time in his career this condition has existed: there is nobody he has to report to who has the standing to say no on taste. Whether Ive's restraint holds up without someone else empowered to enforce it is a real, open question, and it happens to be the only open question left in his story.



The part that's already true

Every other gamechanger had changed a market or a company. Ive changed an assumption, and assumptions are harder to undo than market share. Long after any given iPhone model is forgotten, the idea that a piece of consumer technology should do less, not more, that fewer buttons signal more confidence, that materials should feel permanent rather than disposable, will still be the baseline every designer in the world is quietly working against or working within. He didn't win a round of the game. He wrote a rule nobody else got to vote on, and the industry has been playing by it for twenty years whether it wanted to or not. **■**